Daniel Manginelli

SENIOR GAME DESIGNER · SYSTEMS, CLASS & COMBAT DESIGN

Recife, Brazil · Open to relocation
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SUMMARY

Senior game designer with over eight years in games, designing gameplay systems, classes, spells and progression, and a World of Warcraft player since 2005. I take features from concept through implementation and polish, turning a fantasy into mechanics players can feel, and I believe the best games come from care, study and iteration.

EXPERIENCE

Co-Founder · Creative Director & Game Designer, *Pixel Hound Studios* — Apr 2024 - Present · Recife

- Lead the design of **Mars Incremental** (Steam, Q1 2027): core loop, economy, progression systems and a unique mechanic for each building; managed its game data in spreadsheets (tables of up to 500 entries) and iterated through playtest feedback
- Guide the art team on decisions that shape the player-facing experience; presented the game's design in publisher pitches
- Designed the combat of **Across the Abyss: Voidborn** (Steam, 2024): defeated enemies become weapons, with chain explosions and an elemental system with unique interactions. Shipped to learn the full publishing process end to end
- Designed its bosses and enemies, their attacks and weaknesses, balanced them across both stages, and wrote the stories of its three secondary characters
- Built the studio's development process and implementation pipeline from scratch, working across multiple Git branches

Senior Game Designer, *Hoplon* — Oct 2022 - Jun 2024 · Remote

- Lead designer on five mobile games shipped on Google Play, taking features from high concept and GDD through implementation with engineers, artists and QA to post-launch balancing, working with publishers
- Iterated on mechanics with data-driven workflows, based on soft launch metrics and publisher feedback
- Designed **Mutant Combat Merge**, an idle combat game with merge mechanics, biome bosses and an hour of balanced progression systems
- Tuned **Hex Conquest**'s AI to feel threatening while favoring the player, plus adaptive difficulty

Game Designer, *PUGA Studios* — Jan 2020 - Oct 2022 · Recife

- Lead designer of a midcore mobile game: economy, battle system, content, UI/UX and balancing (NDA)
- Modeled game economies and rewards in spreadsheets, projecting earnings for different player types over time and rebalancing as features were added
- Lead designer of a mid-sized PC/console game, and level designer on a PC indie, including procedurally generated levels

Earlier: Game Design Intern, PUGA Studios (2018): lead designer of *Carnavalência*, a mobile arcade game made with Brazil's Ministry of Culture · Design Intern, CESAR (2018) · Game Developer, Diorama Digital (2016 - 2017): sole programmer of a mobile infinite runner and a mobile VR experience

SELECTED PROJECT

Demon Hunter: a class reimagining for WoW: Forever — 2026 · manginelli.github.io/demon-hunter

A complete class design faithful to the Warcraft III hero: three specializations, spells and talents, a core combat mechanic that rewards constant pressure (Battle Rhythm), five Demon Bloods earned as rewards for hunting demons, original lore that brings the class to the Horde, and a four-wave playable browser prototype I built with AI-assisted development (Claude).

SKILLS & TOOLS

Design: gameplay systems, class and combat design, spells, rewards and progression, economy and balancing, content and level design, rapid prototyping, design documentation

Data: data-driven workflows, economy modeling in spreadsheets, soft launch metrics, paid media campaign analytics (marketing agency, 2026 - present)

Tools: Godot, Unity, Unreal Engine, C#, Git/GitHub, Google Sheets, Jira, Notion, Miro, Claude (AI-assisted prototyping)

EDUCATION, AWARDS & LANGUAGES

Education: Bachelor's Degree in Design, CESAR School (2018 - 2022) · Bachelor's Degree in Law, UFPE (2012 - 2017)

Awards: SBGames 2022 Best Papers, 3rd place short paper in Arts & Design (emergent behavior in Elden Ring) · GameJamPlus Recife 2019, 1st place (*Statue Knight*)

Languages: Portuguese (native) · English (full professional proficiency)